

been universal, with schooling provided for both boys and girls. A boy's education included training to fight in wars because the Aztecs were a culture with a proud warrior tradition. By 1520 they had an empire that stretched across Mexico from the Gulf of Mexico to the Pacific.

Like the Maya, the Aztecs had a large number of gods, related to the creation of the cosmos, to the sun, and to fertility, death, and war. The two main temples on the pyramid in Tenochtitlán were dedicated to Huitzilopochtli, the god of war and Tlaloc, the god of rain and water. Another important god was

Quetzalcoatl, the feathered serpent god of wind, creativity, and fertility. Although the Aztecs had a rich culture that showed particular respect for poetry and song, they are remembered more for their human sacrifices. They believed that if they did not satisfy the gods with sacrifices, the sun would not continue its journey across the sky.

Their rites took many different forms, some more brutal than others. One performed for the fire god, Huehuetotl, involved captives being anesthetized and thrown into a fire. Before they died, priests retrieved them using hooks and removed their hearts. >>

Civilizations of America, c. 1520

The Incas occupied the Andes mountains of South America. The Aztecs were centered on Tenochtitlán, now Mexico City, while the Maya inhabited the Yucatán Peninsula.

KEY

- Aztec Empire
- Inca Empire
- Maya cultural region

0 2000 km
0 2000 miles



The beating heart was lifted into the air by the priest, who pronounced it "precious eagle cactus fruit" as an offering to the sun god.

The priest drove a flint or obsidian knife into the breast of the victim, killing him almost instantaneously, then slit the arteries around the heart in order to pull it from the body.

The fire in which the heart was burned was contained in a special vessel carved to represent an eagle.

The sacrificial victim was stretched out on his back over a stone by a number of assistants, usually four.

The victim's body was tossed down the staircase after the sacrifice.

Aztec sacrifice

In this depiction of an Aztec sacrifice, the pyramid temple represents the Sacred Snake Mountain, where, according to Aztec mythology, Huitzilopochtli, god of war and the sun, dismembered his sister, the moon goddess Coyolxauqui.

